lost ground and, leading by example, is the titular head of the over-600-year-old erstwhile royal family of Mysuru, Yaduveer Krishnadatta Chamaraja Wadiyar. On April 15, a day after a Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) mega rally headlined by Prime Minister Narendra Modi was convened on the grounds of the Maharaja College in the city, the 32-year-old scion of the erstwhile royal family was seen at the venue, helping civic workers clean up the place. A graduate from the University of Massachusetts, he was anointed the 27th custodian of the Wadiyars in May 2015. For Yaduveer,



REACHING THE MASSES Yaduveer Krishnadatta Chamaraja Wadiyar campaigns in Chamundeshwari

however, the cleanliness drive could mean more than an effort to restore Mysuru's lost sanitary shine. It is being seen as an attempt by the titular royal to prove wrong detractors who paint the 'Maharaja' in colours of inaccessible elitism since he "stays in a palace". As the BJP candidate for the Mysuru-Kodagu Lok Sabha constituency in the ongoing general election, it is important for Yaduveer to be seen as a leader who can reach and represent the masses. It was something the BJP candidate stressed on as his open-top campaign vehicle snaked through the villages on the outskirts of Mysuru city on April 20. "My ancestors, too, were born and raised in the palace,



SIDDARAMAIAH HAS THROWN HIS WEIGHT BEHIND CONGRESS's M. LAKSHMAN IN MYSURU-KOGADU, SAYING "IF LAKSHMAN WINS, IT'S AS GOOD AS ME WINNING"

yet they worked amongst the people. I will follow those same tenets." Mysuru's erstwhile rulers had ushered in a golden age in the region, he said, "In much the same manner, Prime Minister Narendra Modi is heralding a golden age for India. We have to support him."

The Mysuru-Kodagu parliamentary seat has been in the firm grip of the BJP since 2014. In both the past two elections, the party's sitting MP, Pratap Simha, defeated the Congress rival by over 31,000 votes and about 138,000 votes, in 2014 and 2019, respectively. This time, however, the BJP has brought in a fresh face in the constituency with Yaduveer. According to party insiders, fielding Yaduveer in Mysuru is being seen as a masterstroke, given the reverence the locals have for members of the erstwhile royal family.

The 32-year-old is not the first from his family to have tried his luck in politics. Before him, his grand-uncle Srikantadatta Narasimharaja Wadiyar—whom Yaduveer succeeded as custodian of the Wadiyars—was a four-time Congress MP from Mysuru. The constituency votes for the 2024 Lok Sabha election in the second phase on April 26, and pitted against Yaduveer is the Congress's M. Lakshman who, as a Karnataka Pradesh Congress Committee spokesperson, has been a local face in the region. What the Wadiyar scion needs to contend with, however, is Karnataka chief minister Siddaramaiah. Mysuru—spread across two Lok Sabha constituencies, Mysuru-Kodagu and Chamarajnagar—happens to be the veteran Congress leader's hometown. The CM has thrown his might behind Lakshman and Sunil Bose, the Congress nominee from Chamarajnagar. "If you want to keep Siddaramaiah's credibility intact, you have to give Lakshman a lead," the CM said at a rally on April 3 when the Mysuru-Kodagu candidate filed his nomination. "If Lakshman wins, it's as good as me winning."

While the Congress is banking on its welfare guarantees and Siddaramaiah's popularity in Mysuru, it's equally playing up the caste card, as Lakshman is a member of the dominant Vokkaliga community, believed to be the second largest caste group in Karnataka. Meanwhile, Yaduveer's twin poll planks are heritage and development, which he says are the main concerns in Mysuru. "We want to have a very organic development of this constituency keeping in mind our heritage and Nature and moving forward," he tells INDIA TODAY. "Our village atmosphere and environment also require conservation, but we need all the facilities and development that we have in the city centres as well. So we need to do that jointly and preserve our ancient traditions as well as bring in every modern requirement."

The female vote will be key in deciding the winner, as they are the beneficiaries of the Congress's guarantees, says political analyst Muzaffar Assadi. "It will be a tough fight," he says, since the gap between the two candidates is narrow. ■